Minang Mujahida Dirampatan-Sharief

Dr. Minang Mujahida Dirampatan-Sharief is a Meranaw academic, linguist, cultural heritage advocate, theater artist, and peace weaver who spent close to five decades shaping the intellectual and cultural life of Mindanao from her home base at Mindanao State University (MSU) in Marawi City.

She is one of the pioneering graduates of Mindanao State University (MSU) Main Campus, and later earned her doctorate from the University of the Philippines, going on to spend close to five decades giving back to the very institution that first formed her — alongside a generation of Meranaw women scholars who collectively redefined what was possible for their community.

Her meticulous work documenting the Meranaw language for the national Filipino lexicon stands as one of the most substantive Bangsamoro contributions to Philippine linguistic scholarship on record.

Beyond the classroom and the conference hall, she has consistently described herself in terms that say more about her than any title could: *guro, peace weaver, at culture bearer* — teacher, peace weaver, and culture bearer — words she offered not as biography but as a statement of life's purpose.

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EARLY LIFE AND BACKGROUND

Minang Mujahida Dirampatan-Sharief was born around 1952 in Lanao, in the highland lake country of Mindanao that the Meranaw people have called home for centuries.

She grew up in a community where Islamic faith, maratabat — that finely calibrated Meranaw sense of dignity, honor, and communal pride — and the rhythms of Meranaw cultural life were not abstract principles but the actual texture of daily existence.

Lanao in that era was not an easy place to grow up as an ambitious young woman with academic aspirations. Like many Meranaw women of her generation, she came of age in a world that tended to prioritize men when it came to schooling and professional formation. She and the women around her broke that tradition — not loudly or dramatically, but steadily and with conviction — choosing the long road of learning at a time when that choice carried real social friction.

Her deep immersion in Meranaw cultural identity — its oral traditions, its language, its layered cosmology of faith and community — would become the foundation for everything she would later build in the academy and beyond. She did not arrive at her life's work by accident. She was formed for it.

EDUCATION

Dr. Dirampatan-Sharief is one of the pioneering graduates of Mindanao State University (MSU) Main Campus in Marawi City — part of the foundational generation of students who shaped the university's earliest academic culture and carried its promise forward.

She later pursued advanced studies at the University of the Philippines, where she earned her doctoral degree.

She and her contemporaries — among them fellow MSU alumna and faculty luminary Dr. Medaylin B. Acraman — were among the pioneering Meranaw women to hold doctoral degrees from one of the country's most academically rigorous institutions. This was no small thing for women from Lanao in that era, and it spoke directly to the combination of intellectual capacity and personal tenacity that defined their generation.

Returning to Mindanao after her graduate studies, Dr. Dirampatan-Sharief came back to the institution that had first formed her — this time as a faculty member, a researcher, and a builder. She brought with her not only an advanced academic credential but a clear sense of mission: to put what she had learned in service of the community she had come from, at the foot of Lake Lanao.

ACADEMIC CAREER

Dr. Dirampatan-Sharief's professional home for close to five decades was Mindanao State University (MSU) in Marawi City — the same institution where she had been a pioneering student, and to which she returned as a faculty member committed to deepening what the university could offer the Meranaw people.

She and Dr. Acraman are recognized as two of the pioneering MSU graduates who stayed on to become foundational voices in the university's language education program, having shaped its approach to English language instruction from the institution's early years and continuing their contributions through the 2010s — a tenure spanning close to five decades.

Dr. Minang Mujahida Dirampatan-Sharief



Photo not yet available. Contributions welcome.

Born

c. 1952
Lanao, Mindanao, Philippines

Nationality

Filipino

Ethnicity

Meranaw (Maranao)

Religion

Islam (Sunni)

Education

Pioneering Graduate, Mindanao State University
Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.)
University of the Philippines

Occupations

- Academic / Professor
- Linguist
- Cultural Heritage Advocate
- Theater Artist
- Peace Weaver

Institutional Affiliation

Mindanao State University
Main Campus, Marawi City

Her institutional responsibilities across that long career covered significant ground.

As Chairperson of the English Department at MSU Marawi, she led one of the university's most strategically important academic units. The role was not merely administrative. It demanded a sophisticated, culturally sensitive understanding of the particular challenges that Meranaw students faced in navigating English — a colonial-era language that functioned simultaneously as a medium of instruction, a professional credential, and a marker of social access. Getting that navigation right, for students who often arrived at MSU as the first in their families to reach higher education, required both linguistic expertise and genuine empathy for the people in the classroom.

As Director of the Pre-University Center at MSU, Dr. Dirampatan-Sharief oversaw the foundational academic bridge programs that prepared incoming students — many of them from rural Lanao communities — for the demands of university-level study. For a student population that often arrived without the academic scaffolding that their counterparts in Metro Manila or Cebu took for granted, the Pre-University Center was frequently the difference between success and early departure. Her leadership of that center was, in real and practical terms, an act of community building.

In her later years at MSU, she served as a senior academic consultant for the Meranaw Cultural Heritage Center (MCHC), contributing her expertise to the center's work in preserving Meranaw arts, oral literature, historical narrative, and indigenous knowledge systems.

At the First MSU Applied Linguistics Conference in March 2014 — a milestone event for the university — she and Dr. Acraman were the featured plenary speakers. Her address covered current issues and trends in English Language Teaching across the globe, a reminder that her intellectual reach was never limited to Lanao, even as her sense of obligation to Lanao never wavered.

Key Roles Held
• Former Chairperson, English Department (MSU) • Former Director, Pre-University Center (MSU) • Senior Consultant, Meranaw Cultural Heritage Center (MCHC)
Notability
Pioneering Meranaw linguist, cultural advocate, and theater artist; one of the pioneering graduates of MSU Marawi's Main Campus, who went on to serve her alma mater for close to five decades as a foundational voice in language education
Known For
• Documenting Meranaw words for the national Filipino lexicon through the UP *Ambagang Wika* Project (2009) • Defending the indigenous linguistic dignity of the word *Ampatuan* at a national language conference • Close to five decades of leadership in MSU's English and Pre-University programs • Cultural heritage and theater advocacy across the Bangsamoro region
Pull Quote
"Ako po ay isang guro, peace weaver at culture bearer." *("I am a teacher, a peace weaver, and a culture bearer.")* *— Dr. Minang Mujahida Dirampatan-Sharief*

LANGUAGE ADVOCACY: THE AMBAGANG WIKA PROJECT

One of Dr. Dirampatan-Sharief's most concrete and lasting contributions to Philippine cultural life is her work in documenting the Meranaw language for the national Filipino lexicon.

Under the framework of the *Ambagang Wika* project — a national language initiative convened by the UP Sentro ng Wikang Filipino in collaboration with the Filipinas Institute of Translation and the Office of the Chancellor of UP Diliman — she presented a paper titled *Sampung Piling Salitang Meranao* (Ten Selected Meranaw Words) at a national conference held at UP Diliman on March 5 to 6, 2009.

The conference gathered language scholars and researchers from across the Philippine archipelago to contribute words from regional languages into a planned national Filipino dictionary, the *UP Diksiyonaryong Filipino*. The goal was ambitious: to build a monolingual Filipino dictionary that would finally reflect the country's actual linguistic diversity, not just its Tagalog-dominant center.

Dr. Dirampatan-Sharief's contribution from Marawi went beyond a simple word list. She anchored each selected Meranaw term in its cultural, historical, and societal context — treating the language as a living archive of Meranaw civilization, not as a curiosity or an ethnographic footnote.

The methodology she brought to this work reflected years of deliberate, community-grounded research:

- **Linguistic Surveys** — Broad surveys conducted among MSU students, faculty members, and Meranaw community elders to identify candidate words and establish their range of usage
- **Informant Interviews** — In-depth conversations with recognized culture-bearers who carried the living, nuanced meanings of terms that dictionaries rarely capture
- **Lexical Mapping** — Careful gathering and vetting of terms to identify proper linguistic equivalents and contextual synonyms across registers
- **Historical and Etymological Research** — Investigation of the deep roots, origins, and societal significance of each selected word
- **Collaborative Translation** — Coordinated work with MSU's Filipino-language faculty to render nuanced Meranaw concepts as accurately as possible in the national language

The result was a rigorous scholarly contribution that insisted Meranaw deserved the same lexicographic seriousness applied to Tagalog, Cebuano, or Ilocano — and demonstrated that the expertise to deliver that seriousness existed right there in Marawi.

She framed the larger project in terms that were at once scholarly and deeply personal. In her own words at the conference: *Ang ating etnisidad ay di dapat maging sanhi ng di pagkakaunawaan* — our ethnicity should not be the cause of misunderstanding — and she offered a vision of a Filipino dictionary that would finally prove, as she put it, that the more than a hundred languages of the Philippines belong to one people, and can serve as a road toward mutual understanding, peace, and progress.

IN DEFENSE OF WORDS: THE AMPATUAN CASE

Perhaps no single episode captures Dr. Dirampatan-Sharief's intellectual courage and cultural commitment more clearly than her intervention at a national language conference when the word *Ampatuan* was being evaluated as a candidate for "Word of the Year."

The context was as charged as it gets. The November 2009 Maguindanao Massacre — one of the worst acts of political violence in Philippine recorded history, in which 58 people including 32 journalists were killed in an ambush attributed to members of the Ampatuan political clan — had exploded the name into national consciousness under the darkest possible shadow. In its immediate aftermath, the name *Ampatuan* carried an almost unbearable weight in Filipino public discourse. To many, it had become, in practice, a byword for political warlordism and impunity.

When the word surfaced as a candidate for "Word of the Year" — a designation that would effectively fix its massacre-era meaning into the national linguistic record — Dr. Dirampatan-Sharief stepped forward.

She reminded the assembled academics that the word *Ampatuan* had roots and a meaning that predated any political dynasty or criminal event by centuries.

In its original Bangsamoro linguistic context, the word carries two deeply significant components: *tua,* which conveys the essence of power, inner strength, and dignity; and *tuan,* a term for a high Muslim religious authority or spiritual leader. Far from a dark symbol, the word in its indigenous context was — and is — a dignified one. It named a quality, a lineage, and a kind of authority rooted in spiritual and communal standing.

Her argument was not to deny the massacre or erase its victims from the historical record. She was not asking anyone to forget or forgive. Her argument was more precise and more principled than that: if the word was going to enter the national dictionary as a consequence of recent events, then its original, noble meaning had to stand in that dictionary alongside the modern historical association. To allow the massacre to be the word's sole definition would be to let violence accomplish a second act of destruction — this time not of lives, but of language, memory, and identity.

The argument prevailed. The episode became, among those present, a marker of what linguistic advocacy actually looks like when it takes seriously the stakes of cultural representation.

Dr. Dirampatan-Sharief's position grew directly from her core conviction: that language is not simply a communication tool but a sacred vessel for a people's dignity, history, and self-understanding. Letting that vessel be defined by the worst act ever committed in a family's name — without pushback, without the full linguistic record — is, in her view, a cultural tragedy that compounds the original one.

CULTURAL HERITAGE AND PEACE ADVOCACY

Dr. Dirampatan-Sharief's reach has always extended well beyond the formal boundaries of university life.

She has served as a lecturer on Maranao cultural heritage for programs organized under the National Commission for Culture and the Arts (NCCA), covering Meranaw historical perspective, Sultanate genealogy, traditional cultural practices, and the performing arts traditions of the Meranaw people. Her work with the NCCA placed her in national conversations about Indigenous cultural identity at a time when Mindanao's heritage was regularly misrepresented or simply ignored in mainstream Philippine cultural programming.

She is also known, though not always acknowledged prominently in her academic profile, as a theater artist. Theater, in the Meranaw cultural context, is far more than entertainment. It is memory work — a communal act of passing history, identity, and values from one generation to the next through embodied performance. Her engagement with theater has been, in this sense, a natural extension of the same cultural preservation instinct that drives her linguistic work.

Her own articulation of her Muslim faith and Meranaw identity is worth sitting with directly. She has described her *jihad* — her personal striving — as *upang maging tunay na Muslim sa puso, sa isip at gawa*: to be a true Muslim in heart, mind, and deed. And her *maratabat,* her personal code of dignity, is *ang ipagtanggol ang tama at mabuti at iwasan ang mali at masama*: to defend what is right and good, and to avoid what is wrong and bad.

These are not abstract religious formulas. They are the operating principles of a life lived under repeated pressure — from the stigma that Muslim Mindanao has carried in the national imagination, from the physical and political violence that has repeatedly descended on Marawi, from the long effort required simply to be taken seriously as a Meranaw Muslim woman in Philippine academic and public life.

She has explicitly named and rejected the conflation of Meranaw Muslim identity with terrorism. In one public address, she introduced herself in terms that were both a correction and a declaration: *Isang Meranao, Muslim, Bangsamoro Filipino, hindi terorista* — a Meranaw, Muslim, Bangsamoro Filipino, not a terrorist. In the years that followed the 2017 Marawi Siege, those words took on an even sharper urgency.

LEGACY

Dr. Minang Mujahida Dirampatan-Sharief represents something that becomes rarer the more you look for it in academic life: a scholar who never left her people.

She had the credentials, the training, and the connections to pursue a comfortable career at any major Philippine university. She chose Marawi instead — and she stayed through decades of political instability, armed conflict, and communal hardship that would have sent many people in the opposite direction.

Her legacy operates at several levels simultaneously.

As a linguist, she made the Meranaw language visible and legible within the national Filipino cultural framework at a time when the languages of Mindanao were treated, at best, as regional curiosities. Her contributions to the *Ambagang Wika* project gave Meranaw a place at the national lexicographic table that it had long deserved but rarely been offered.

As an academic administrator, she built and led the institutional structures — the English Department, the Pre-University Center — that gave successive generations of young Meranaw students a genuine path through higher education. That is not a small thing. In communities where formal education was both a privilege and a daily act of cultural navigation, steady, competent, culturally grounded academic leadership mattered enormously.

As a cultural advocate, she defended the integrity of Meranaw identity — in language, in the arts, in historical narrative — with the precision and persistence that only genuine, long-term commitment produces. The Ampatuan case alone would be enough to secure her place in the history of Bangsamoro intellectual life.

And as a peace weaver, she modeled, across decades, a way of being Meranaw, Muslim, and Filipino that refuses both marginalization and caricature — insisting, by example, that these identities are not in contradiction and that their bearer is not, and has never been, anyone's problem to define.

EDITORIAL NOTES

- Her approximate birth year (c. 1952) is derived from a February 2010 Philippine Center for Investigative Journalism profile that described her as 58 years old at that time.
- The precise name, date, and venue of the national language conference at which she intervened in the *Ampatuan* word debate have not been independently confirmed in the sources consulted for this article. Editors with access to Komisyon sa Wikang Filipino (KWF) or UP Sentro ng Wikang Filipino conference records are encouraged to supply this information.
- The "Meranaw Cultural Heritage Center (MCHC)" is referenced as stated in the primary source document. Independent verification of this institution's formal name and current status is recommended.

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